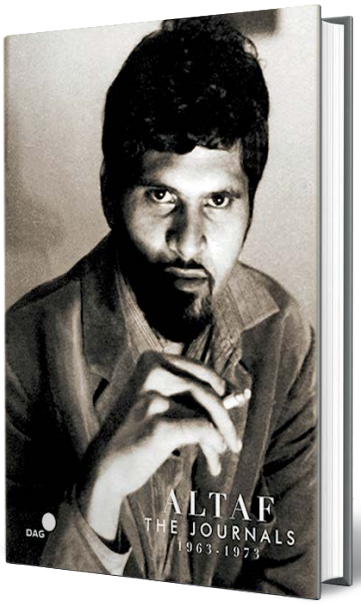


ALTAF: THE JOURNALS, 1963-1973
Edited by Sasha Altaf
DELHI ART GALLERY | **₹4,500; 501** pages

BOOKS

CHRONICLE OF INTERESTING TIMES

The incisively observed *Journals* of the painter **Altaf Mohammedi** provide a fascinating glimpse into 1960s London

Altaf (born Altaf Mohammedi, in 1942) was an Indian painter of the same generation as Nilima Sheikh, Gulammohammed Sheikh, Vivan Sundaram and Nalini Malani. Whereas older Indian artists, including many from the group called the Progressives, made their way to Europe in the late 1940s and early 1950s (shortly followed by Altaf's older sister, the artist Nasreen Mohamedi), people like Altaf, Sundaram and Malani landed in Europe to study art in the turbulent 1960s.

Coming from a well-to-do business family, Altaf received support from home as he grappled with the business of living in London as a young art student. The stay in London begins in 1962 and ends in 1966, after which Altaf returns to India and settles in Bombay, joining the group of young artists, filmmakers, theatre people and poets who form the most exciting and transformational cultural milieu seen till then in newly independent India.

After his death at the age of 63 in 2005, Altaf's family discovered a stack of neatly preserved journals he maintained from 1963 to 1973. The journals, each meticulously dated with a start and end date, record first Altaf's time in London and while travelling in Europe and West Asia, and then the time in Bombay, till just after the Bangladesh War.



EXHIBITION

Black Beauties

Nilanjan Das's exhibition of charcoal on canvas paintings, *Savage Beauty*, explores the majestic and graceful form of horses

Since time immemorial, artists have been drawn to horses, from nameless Palaeolithic cave painters to Western artists like Eugène Delacroix and George Stubbs and, closer home, the likes of M.F. Husain and Sunil Das. There's something about the muscular equine form that poses a satisfying–and irresistible–technical challenge for the artist.



For *Savage Beauty*, his deep dive into equine art, Nilanjan Das, Group Creative Editor, India Today, chose a timeless tool–the charcoal stick, which, perfectionist that he is, he painstakingly fashioned himself. "The choice of charcoal on canvas for this exhibition stems from its timeless and versatile nature. Horses, with their graceful forms, allow the me-